



“ Under her leadership, SBI pursued discipline and became a formidable force. Credit was given only when there was a strong case. Arundhati is a very strong person and has always stood her ground”

DEEPAK PAREKH
Former Chairman, HDFC

48 | were obvious. It was clear that the future was going to be digital.”

“We were at an inflexion point. Technology had to be adopted but the legacy mindset was a challenge,” says Sunil Srivasatva, who was then Deputy Managing Director (Digital Banking & Corporate Strategy).

At her behest, an offsite at Lonavala for the top brass, including independent directors, got things moving. It was also attended by the sharpest minds from Microsoft, McKinsey, BCG, Gartner and Oracle etc. “There was a lot of discussion on the digital future of the bank,” says Srivastava, who also remembers that it was perhaps the first time that the entire team travelled by bus. That effort paid off with the board soon giving the green signal for the highest tech spend ever by the bank till then. “Taking along the board made a big difference,” he adds. At that stage, while core banking had been stabilised, the challenge lay in the inevitability of digital banking where SBI had lagged others. “She was not thinking in an incremental manner. Once there was the buy-in from the board, there was no stopping the transformation.” Parekh says a lot of digital “pathbreaking work,” including YONO, was done by Bhattacharya, before Dinesh Khara “took it to the next level.”

TAKING FRESH GUARD

After completing her term at SBI in 2017, Bhattacharya spent the next year—also her gardening leave—giving lectures and attending investor conferences. Not all of this was related to banking. In fact, the first lecture was

at Welham Girls School in Dehradun at their annual day. The crowd was a mix of students and alumni. “The principal told me I would have to speak in a manner that could be understood by a student in the sixth grade and also by a 70-year-old,” she says. Post October 2018, she joined a few boards and took up consulting assignments.

Quite unexpectedly, during this period, a head-hunter reached out to her for a position at Salesforce. “I was told the organisation is still small in India but had big growth plans. They wanted a country head,” she says. That was in 2019. Bhattacharya sat on the decision for five-six months. “I was apprehensive about starting a new journey at that age. Plus, it was an entirely new area, though the world of IT has always excited me.”

Towards the end of that year, Salesforce’s founder, Marc Benioff, invited her to the company’s San Francisco headquarters. “He realised I was not able to make up my mind and asked me to meet with the team to decide.” After detailed conversations with the team, Bhattacharya was comfortable, and towards the end of the trip, Benioff gave her a copy of his book. “I enjoyed reading stories of someone who walks the talk. On the flight back home, I pretty much made up my mind to take up the offer.”

THE TECH JOURNEY

Salesforce is a young organisation where most people address Bhattacharya by her first name. “I was already used to people calling me Arundhati during my stint in New York,” she says. Among the many things that excite her is